

BOOK 1 OF FIFTEEN



THE KEYS OF MOROCCO

The Olive Fire

± 200

Walili (Volubilis), at the foot of the Zerhoun

DARIJA FOR KIDS · AGES 9 AND UP

WHERE THIS BOOK TAKES PLACE



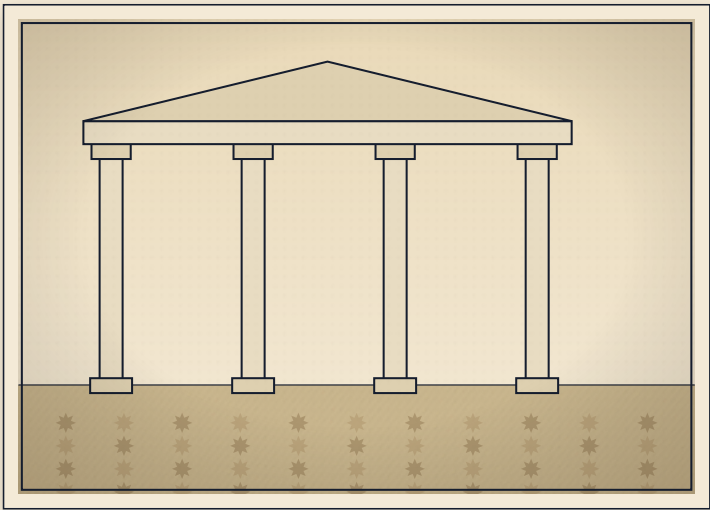
Walili (Volubilis), at the foot of the Zerhoun. The map is drawn in simplified form.

WHERE THIS BOOK SITS IN TIME



Fifteen books, from Roman times to today. The years are spaced evenly, not to scale.

DRAWING



Drawing. As soon as there is a photograph of this place, it will be here.

De afspraak met de lezer



This book is made up, but not carelessly.

The things that happen in it really happened: the cities, the battles, the journeys, the books and the people who made history. What is known about all that has been checked, and has not been made prettier than it was.

The boys and girls who tell the story are made up. They did not exist, and the key that passes from hand to hand never existed either. It had to be that way: about ordinary children from those times we know almost nothing — and they are exactly the people you want to be sitting next to when something big happens.

Wherever the story fills a gap with imagination, it says so at the back of the book, under «What really happened». Read that part. It is the most gripping thing in the book, because that is where you see how much stranger the real story often is.

Tala holds the key to the storehouse and the overseer wants it. When the whole city's oil is at risk, she has to choose between obeying and being right.

Verteld door Tala, eleven, daughter of an oil-press owner who has fallen ill.

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CHAPTER 1

The key



Tala woke up because of the smell.

Olives. Pressed olives, warm and bitter. The whole city smelled of it in these weeks. She lay still for a moment and listened. Outside, the big press was already creaking. That meant she was late.

She jumped off her bed and pulled her dress over her head.

“Tala!” her mother called from below. “The door!”

The door. Of course, the door.

Since her father had fallen ill, Tala did his work. Every morning she walked to the storehouse behind the house and unlocked the door. The jars stood there. A hundred jars, filled to the brim with oil, ready to go to the harbour.

The key hung on a cord around her neck. It was bronze and as long as her hand. Her grandfather had forged it, long before she existed. Its head had eight points, like a star.

“Don’t lose it,” her father had said. He had said it quietly, because louder was no longer possible for him. “Nothing else opens that door.”

Tala ran down the stairs, past the kitchen, across the courtyard. It was still early. The sun stood just above the hills and the stones were cold under her feet.

There was a man at the storehouse.

She stopped.

He was big and he wore the red cloak of the overseer. Marcus. Everyone in Walili knew Marcus, and nobody liked him.

“You’re late,” he said.

“I’m on time,” said Tala.

She knew she should not have said that. She said it anyway.

Marcus looked at her. Then he held out his hand.

“Give me that key. A child has no business guarding a hundred jars.”

Tala took a step back.

In her head she heard her father. *Nothing else opens that door.* And she thought of something else, something she had seen yesterday and had decided was nothing.

Two jars that were not in their place.

“Well?” said Marcus.

Tala closed her hand around the bronze. It had grown warm from her skin.

“No,” she said.

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CHAPTER 2

Two jars



Marcus did not laugh. He did not get angry either. That was the worst of it.

He lowered his hand, straightened his cloak and said: “As you wish.” Then he walked away, out of the alley, without looking back.

Tala stood still until she could no longer hear his footsteps. Only then did she notice her hands were shaking.

She opened the door.

Inside it was dark and cool. The jars stood in rows of ten, with straw between them so they would not knock against each other. Ten rows of ten. Every morning she counted them. Her father had taught her that when she was six, and back then it was still a game.

She started on the left and counted aloud, as always.

At the back row she stopped.

There were nine.

Tala counted again. Nine. She walked around the row, crouched, looked behind the straw. Nine.

Yesterday she had seen something odd too. Two jars standing the wrong way, handles towards the wall instead of towards the path. She had thought: someone did that in a hurry. She had set them straight and thought no more about it.

Now there was one fewer.

She sat down in the doorway with her back against the post and her knees pulled up, and tried to work out what to do.

She could tell her mother. But her mother already had enough this month: a sick husband upstairs, a house full of people who had to be paid, and a harvest that had to go to the

harbour in three weeks.

She could tell Marcus. Marcus was the overseer. That was his job.

Tala looked at the alley where he had disappeared.

No.

“You’re in the way,” said a voice.

She started. In front of her stood a boy about her own age, in a leather apron, his arms full of bundles of kindling. His hands were black.

“I’m not in the way,” said Tala. “This is my door.”

“Then you’re in the way of your own door.”

His name was Yidir and he worked at the smithy at the end of the street. Tala knew him by sight the way you know everyone in Walili by sight, and no further.

She got up to let him past. He did not go past.

“You count every morning,” he said.

“How do you know that?”

“I walk past every morning.”

Tala hesitated. Then she said it anyway, because it had to come out and because he happened to be standing there.

“One is gone.”

Yidir put his bundles down on the ground.

“One?” he said. “Then you’ve been lucky. We’re missing six iron bars.”

DID YOU KNOW?

Volubilis — Walili in Arabic — was a real Roman city near Meknès, with thousands of inhabitants, bathhouses and stone streets.

How oil is made



That afternoon Tala stood at the press, as she did every day during the harvest.

The press was a hollowed-out stone as big as a cart, with a round stone inside it that a donkey dragged round and round. The olives went in, were crushed, and what came out was a thick brown mass that looked like nothing at all.

That was the part that always disappointed strangers. “*That* is oil?” they would ask. No. That was the beginning.

The mass went into round mats of woven reed. The mats were stacked on top of each other under the beam press, and then two men turned the screw, slowly, as if they had all the time in the world. Under the stack ran a channel.

That was where it came out.

First water, cloudy and dirty. Then, after a while, something else. Something that floated on the water and was greener than anything Tala knew.

The first time, her father had taken her by the neck and held her head over it. “Smell,” he had said. “That’s it. If it smells like *that*, it’s good. If it smells of nothing, you waited too long.”

She had lied then and said she could smell it. Now she really could.

Walili lived on this. Not on the mosaic floors that visitors walked across, not on the columns on the square, not on the stone streets. On this. On pressed olives that went into jars, onto carts to the coast, and onto ships to places whose names were all Tala knew of them.

She watched the channel and the mats and the donkey, and all the while she was thinking about ninety-nine jars.

Six iron bars, Yidir had said. From the smithy.

Iron was expensive. Oil was expensive. And both left the city in the same direction: along the road to the harbour.

“Tala.” One of the men pointed at the channel. “It’s overflowing.”

She shot forward and pushed the bowl underneath, too late. A stream of oil ran over the stone and disappeared between the joints.

A finger thick, maybe two. Enough for a family for a week.

The man said nothing about it. That made it worse.



DID YOU KNOW?

The city lived on olive oil. Dozens of presses have been excavated, and they worked on the same principle as the presses still used in Morocco today.

The floors were covered in mosaic. Part of it is still there, in the open air.

The population was largely Amazigh; Roman and Amazigh life ran through one another here.

THAT WAS THE BEGINNING



You have read the beginning. How it ends is in the whole book — and after that another fourteen books, until the key ends up on a table in Utrecht.

The whole book and the whole series:
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